

Vertigo

Newsletter of the New Zealand Alpine Club, Wellington Section
www.facebook.com/nzacwellington

Photo Lorraine Johns ascends the summit rocks of Aoraki/Mount Cook (Photo: Simon Bell)

Section News

February Section Night

The Wellington Section annual summer BBQ will, once again, be held at Ferg's Kayaks on the waterfront. This is a great opportunity for members to pop down for a climb and enjoy something to eat afterward.

Sausages, including vegetarian options, will be offered and Ferg's entry will be discounted as usual to club members.

Where: Ferg's Kayak's

Time: 6.30pm

Date: Monday 10 February

Come down, bring a friend, have a climb and hear what's happening at the club - we'd love to see you!

March Section Night - Aoraki/Mount Cook and Elie De Beaumont

Lorraine Johns will talk about surviving ten days on the loose in Aoraki/Mount Cook National Park. Just like Freda before her, Lorraine was surrounded only by the company of men and very large spiders. On such a trip, she needed to be able to fend for herself, which included estimating the minimum amount of chocolate required to retain the appearance of sanity, conducting stealth raids on the hut food boxes (and discovering the culinary delight that is instant mash), learning Swahili, exploring the range of cell phone reception around the Tasman Valley, and managing to exist in the same clothes for just a little too long ...

When they weren't busy lazing in the hut and beating south island climbers at cards, Lorraine and her team also climbed the Anzac Peaks, Cook, Vancouver, Glacier Dome, Aylmer, Hochstetter Dome, Green, Walter, Elie De Beaumont, and The Footstool. Lorraine will focus mainly on the ascents of Mount Cook and Elie De Beaumont, but steel yourself for gratuitous shots of other mouth-watering alpine vistas. For those who haven't already climbed these peaks, but would like to, Lorraine will also talk about how you might prepare for such a trip (or at least, reveal where you can charge your cell phone while at Plateau Hut).

Section Nights are at the Tararua Tramping Club clubrooms, 4 Moncrieff Street, Mount Victoria, Wellington on the second Monday of every month. New and prospective members are welcome. Meetings start 8.00 pm with tea & coffee afterwards

NZAC Wellington Section Website

The Wellington section website <http://www.nzalpine.wellington.net.nz/> is up and running after a period of time of being unavailable. Don't forget we are also on Facebook if you're looking for information about upcoming events, etc. www.facebook.com/nzacwellington

Trip Reports

The old and the New at Pioneer Hut

Dave Bamford

In Late November Club members Paul Maxim, Sean Buchanan, Colin Monteath and Dave Bamford had 3 great days at Pioneer Hut. They all climbed Glacier Peak, Sean and Paul climbed Lendenfeld whilst Monteath and Bamford went photographing! They went down the Fox Glacier to Chancellor Hut via West Hoe Pass.

Left: Mts Haast , Lendenfeld Tasman and Torres from West Hoe Pass. Right: Below Pioneer Hut looking back to the main divide.



Trad climbing with the Canty-Westlanders

Lorraine Johns

Wellington sectioners, Elizabeth and Lorraine, headed south over the weekend 14-15 December 2013, to take part in one of Canterbury-Westland's trad climbing courses.

Arriving at Christchurch airport on the Friday night, our first challenge was to get across town to our host Nic's garden paradise. We finally made it there to be warmly welcomed by Nic, who was leading the weekend's instruction. We secretly hoped that trad climbing wouldn't be as complicated as catching a bus!

The morning saw an early departure for the Spur Road crag near Timaru, where we were based for the next two days. We were joined by Clayton (Canterbury-Westland's instruction

convenor), Miharu, Volker, Sarah, Rachel, Carolyn and Matt, a great crew of Cantabrians. Also instructing were the enthusiastic Nick and Lee.

Surrounded by sun, breeze, and pine trees, within minutes of arriving at the crag the soft North Islanders nearly succumbed to an outbreak of pollen. Allergies aside, the students were a captive audience for Nick's introduction to the basic principles of gear placement. We spent the remainder of the morning posting gear into various slots around the base of the crag, with our instructors assessing our placements and giving us lots of feedback. I managed at least one good one - to my mortification, as I was completely unable to remove it (Volker eventually took pity on my hex).

In the afternoon, we were introduced to the concept of "circular leading". A friend later queried whether this was a "flash new technique" she would need to get up to speed on. Well, as long as your belayer picks the right end of the rope, circular leading means you place gear on top rope, while clipping the non-attended end of the rope. But I can totally see this sparking a new trend.

Four ropes had been rigged for pairs to work their way carefully through the climbs. Our instructors zoomed up and down on fixed lines, inspecting placements, and offering encouragement and advice. I tried to imagine I was undertaking a non-circular lead, and quickly had to apply more chalk ...



By the end of the day confidence and insight were on the up, and it was a merry bunch of climbers that checked into the Timaru holiday park for the night. Here there were many distractions ... beer, nibbles, two flirtatious ducks, the odd sheep joke, a trampoline that looked like a bouncy castle... Well there's nothing like having a good bounce after a day of climbing, albeit the accusatory gaze of one five-year-old girl (who clearly was not impressed at having to share with big people) put an end to at least one bouncing competition.

Dinner was served at a delicious Thai restaurant, replete with mocktails (though at least one southern gentleman pronounced, "why would I have a mocktail when I could have a beer?"). While the rest of us opted for a combo of cars and sleep, Clayton and Sarah decided to walk back - and seemed to be almost as good at doing this as the North Islanders were at catching buses. Matt rescued them from the locals around midnight.

We woke the next day to a decrease in atmospheric pressure. Someone also observed that we were one duck down. Nick had been seen enjoying a duck curry in the preceding hours; we could not be sure that this was unconnected...

For some reason we took the scenic route back to the crag (should have listened to Siri). There, students were split into two groups, with anchors as the initial focus. Acronyms are

handy tools for managing risk and increasing safety, and SERENADE1 was the word of the moment. Similar to Summer Rock's EARNEST, but with a couple of additional checks and no "t" for timely (thank goodness ... I seemed to be doing things in slow motion...).

The day also saw some students increasing the difficulty of their circular leads, and others undertaking some non-circular leading (aka trad climbing!). I settled on muddling my way through a supervised lead.

Suspecting that trad climbing might feel a bit like soloing, I opted to repeat a climb that permitted relaxation and two-handed placements. However, I hadn't counted on the cliff subsiding overnight, increasing the difficulty of the intervening moves! Nick patiently jumared alongside, keeping a watchful eye on the excess of placements I was trying to make. The sun rose and set several times while I fumbled around with the very naughty hex from the previous day. But when I got to the top I was pretty happy – and wanted to try it again!

The weekend had started with Nic asking us what we wanted to get out of the course. Nic's surmising that our expectations had been met was confirmed by our broad grins. The course was extremely well run, and the expertise and teaching ability of our instructors Nic, Nick and Lee was apparent from the outset to the finish. What stood out even more was their kindness, patience and focus, which never wavered as they spent hours hanging in their harnesses on fixed lines, taking every possible opportunity to help us all to become better climbers.

I would really recommend this course to those wanting to learn or improve their trad climbing. Clayton, whose support, tips and encouragement also made for a great course, has kindly indicated that North Island members would be welcome to join in on future courses. And we can honestly say that not one person even threatened to cut the rope on us - only Elizabeth's long hair, when she tried to use it as a rope while belaying.



Hard at work in Timaru, Elizabeth relaxes with the instruction team

Since the course, Elizabeth and I have begun to use our newfound knowledge to train for a trip to the Arapiles in 2014. Thank you Canterbury-Westland for an awesome weekend and the huge boost to our skills and confidence levels.

¹ (Solid and secure, Equal, Redundant, Edges, No shock load, Angles, Direction of pull, (check) Everything).

Organisation and instruction: Nic Harvey, Nick Hanafin, Lee MacIntosh, Clayton Garbes

Circular and non-circular leaders: Matt Crombie, Volker Nock, Miharu Yamamoto, Carolyn Grise, Rachel Price, Sarah Rampley, Elizabeth (Bob) Claridge, Lorraine Johns

High Alpine Skills Course – 12-17 January 2014

Carolyn Ellis

Late in 2013 I spotted an advertisement for scholarships for the Alpine Club's summer alpine skill courses. The scholarships were for women and paid for half the course fees for six women to attend one of the Alpine Club alpine courses to be held over the summer period. The scholarships were available due to a generous donation from the Wellington and Auckland sections of Women Climbing. Generally alpine climbing tends to be pretty blokey but there's nothing else to stop women getting involved so the scholarships are a perfect way to provide some encouragement. As a trainee instructor with both Mountain Safety Council and the Alpine Club I leapt at the opportunity to be able to consolidate and improve my skills for both my own personal climbing as well as for instructing others.

I went ahead and got my application in for one of the High Alpine Skills Courses taking place in January and was thrilled when Sefton rang and told me I was successful. I had some concerns regarding the level of fitness that would be required especially coming off the back of 7 weeks of no physical activity during October and November while recuperating from surgery. As it turned out I had no issues with my fitness or strength and was easily able to keep up. My course was scheduled to take place on 12-17 January 2014 and would be preceded by a week at the Alpine Club annual climbing camp in the Hopkins valley. A perfect way to spend my summer holiday.

Eight students and two instructors (Marty Beare and Laetitia Campe) met on Saturday 11 January at Unwin Lodge and spent a bit of time talking about the plan for the upcoming week.

We were all pretty excited and ready to get on with it. Sadly the course started with a..... fizzle. Although the helicopter was booked to take us into Barron Saddle on Sunday morning, the weather decided to thwart our plans. Subsequently we (8 students and 2 instructors) were at Unwin Lodge for two extra nights while we waited for the weather to play ball. The two days spent at Unwin were not wasted as we spent time getting to know each other while embarking on plenty of rope work in the lounge, pitching practice up grassy (matagouri / spaniard littered) slopes and cam and wire anchor placements at the bouldering wall at Mt Cook Village.



Our instructors kept us well informed as each scheduled helicopter departure time was changed until, finally, Tuesday morning dawned looking more hopeful although far from perfect. By now the plan had changed and instead of heading off to Barron Saddle (where the hut only sleeps 8) we were going to go to Plateau Hut. With a feeling of excitement we headed over to the airport for a 7am takeoff. Our departure was slightly delayed due to our pilot misplacing his car keys but, once he had arrived, we were quickly loaded up and took off into the grey, gusty day. Our pilot showed great skill in landing outside Plateau Hut - the cloud was pretty low and the wind gusty and variable.

Once all the team had arrived we did a quick gear sort out and headed outside where the weather was rapidly improving. With crampons on, we roped up for glacier travel and headed to the far side of the plateau to get our on-the-snow experience underway. We started off with the basics of walking on snow and moved on to self arresting. Once the instructors were happy with the team's ability in self arresting we spent time building snow anchors. After covering off t-slots, mid-clips, top-clips and also some v-threads, top ropes were setup for some ice-climbing.



It was smiles all round as the weather had vastly improved and we were entertained as the sun had its effect on the snow resulting in ice collapsing causing avalanches. Only one caused some consternation as we were showered by a cloud of ice from activity taking part above the area we were operating in. Good thing it stopped where it did – otherwise Wellington section might be in the process of recruiting a replacement newsletter editor. Day one on the snow was deemed a resounding success.

Wednesday dawned bright and sunny so, after an early breakfast, we were back outside to do some pitch climbing on Glacier Dome followed by a lesson in crevasse extraction. Both groups found crevasses to work in and soon embarked on self extraction out of the crevasse and then moved on to assisted hoists.



Crevasse extraction time

As Wednesday evening progressed high winds and rain set in. As we headed to bed the hut was being slammed by strong gusts of wind and the forecast for Thursday was grim - gale force winds and rain. On this occasion the forecast proved to be accurate and we woke on Thursday morning to commence a hut-bound day. With a pee bucket set up in the lobby, trips to the toilet were limited to only the necessary and proved great amusement to those snug inside to see fellow students and climbers don their wet weather gear and goggles, clip onto the rope between the hut and the toilet and struggle there and back. In my own case I was hit by very strong gusts partway back to the hut making forward progress impossible - it was a case of hunkering down and waiting for the gusts to abate before making a dash back to the hut. Our day in the hut wasn't wasted as we went over assisted hoists and covered off several areas of theory including weather, avalanches and navigation. We were given a choice of activities for Friday, the last day of our course. We could either walk out over Cinerama Col and down Boys Glacier or receive further instruction on the mountain before helicoptering out later in the day. Much discussion and negotiation ensued until finally coming to the agreement that four of us would walk out with Marty and four would stay on the mountain with Laetitia before helicoptering out.

I had chosen to walk out with Marty's group and we were underway just before 6am the next morning. The weather was brilliant and we were partway across the plateau when the sun rose.

The walk out was a good hard slog with glacier travel across the plateau, pitching down the other side of Cinerama Col, soft snow plodding down Boys Glacier, scree and rock hopping down to the Tasman Glacier, many ups and downs along the glacier before a climb up the moraine wall near Ball Shelter before joining the track and then the road out towards the carpark – taking close to 12 hrs in all – for me at least.



View from Cinerama Col looking back to Plateau Hut

The walking group had expected the helicoptering group to be off the mountain by mid-afternoon so there was a vague hope that we might be collected by the guys in the four wheel drive at some point before we got to the road end. The two of us at the front were delighted to see the car coming towards us - by this stage our feet were starting to feel the strain of the long walk in climbing boots. It was sheer bliss to remove the boots and stretch the toes as we were whisked back to Unwin Lodge. As it turns out the helicoptering group left the mountain mid morning instead of mid afternoon due to a forecast of rising winds through the day. They'd overflowed us while we were still on the snow.



Approaching the top of Boys Glacier

Notices



The NZAC is excited to announce a brand-new sport! 15th March 2014, Castle Hill

This is your chance to participate in the world's first "Bouldergaine", a brand new event that brings together map sport and rock climbing in a way never seen before!

Bouldering is a type of rock climbing on boulders to a safe height without the need for ropes and harnesses.

Rogaining is an endurance form of orienteering involving locating electronic checkpoints in cross-country terrain.

The Bouldergaine involves a 3hr mini-rogaïne event with bonus point challenges involving scrambling or climbing up to a clicker at a high point near each control. Points are gained by finding the checkpoints, and if you can get there, finding your way up to the clicker.

Castle Hill is one of the most spectacular boulder fields in the world, and at only 80mins from Christchurch, the ideal location for this world premier!

Teams of two will run and climb together. Choose a friend or we can pair you up with someone on the day. This is an all-abilities event, although we do suggest that participants under the age of 14 run with an adult.

See our website www.nbs.org.nz for more info and rules. Places are limited, don't miss out!
Tickets at www.eventopia/bouldergaine

Hazard Warning for Cascade Saddle



A bold red DOC hazard warning sign has recently been placed at Aspiring hut for the Cascade Saddle crossing. The additional hazard warning is for trampers attempting the crossing from the Matukituki valley to the Dart valley.

The Otago Coroner and a local representative Advisory Group proposed improved signage following several recent fatalities on the popular tramping route.

The Matukituki face section of the route above treeline is steep, snowgrassed and exposed with short outcrops and adjacent vertical gullies.

It is particularly hazardous when snow covered or wet if parties are ill-equipped or in-experienced.

Consideration has also been given to a cable placement. However, it is hoped the improved signage will promote more caution and sensible turn-back decisions.

Information supplied by: Geoff Wayatt, Mountain Recreation Ltd

New Product available from Alpine Club – Tru Bolts

The Alpine Club have stainless steel bolts for anchoring hangers and ring hangers to rock available from their online store <https://alpineclub.org.nz/product/stainless-steel-tru-bolts>

Best for harder rock types of all angles except rooves, where glue-in bolts are better.

Dynabolts are not to be used as they have under-sized shaft diameter in relation to the overall bolt diameter; e.g. a 10mm bolt has only an 8mm shaft.

\$3.50 including GST

New Alpine books for sale

Occasional Climber

Alpine Club member, Peter Laurenson, has published the book Occasional Climber. Peter's image collection, built over 25 years, runs to many thousands. He has won NZAC awards consistently over the past decade and has had material published sporadically via photo libraries and in magazines like the Peak, Frequent Traveller, Aspiration and Wilderness Magazine. The images are important, giving the reader a personal perspective on what it's like in the high mountains; but his narrative takes the book well beyond mountain grandeur and beauty. For details on Peter's book please go to http://www.accessprint.co.nz/Occasional_Climber.php

Among Secret Beauties

Brian Wilkin's book, Among Secret Beauties is now available through the Alpine Club online store : <http://alpineclub.org.nz/product/among-secret-beauties>. This book is a memoir of mountaineering in New Zealand and the Himalayas. Climbing entered the world stage in the 1950s: this was the era that produced not only Sir Edmund Hillary but a strong body of world-class New Zealand climbers. In this important and dramatic book Brian Wilkins, who was part of the adventure, shares his experiences of climbing in the Southern Alps and the Himalayas.

New Backcountry Huts poster for sale

Shelter from the Storm authors, as well as various Permolat members have contributed photographs to this new huts poster. All royalty proceeds are going to Permolat as a fundraiser.

Printed and available now from Image Vault. www.imagevault.co.nz

NZ Fine Prints do mail order as well: www.prints.co.nz

Expedition Capital Fund – supporters thank you

Thank you to our three corporate supporters of the NZAC Expedition Capital Fund for their donations to date.



We encourage members to continue supporting these companies to help us grow this fund for the Expeditions of the future.

<https://alpineclub.org.nz/donation/expedition-capital-fund>

Wellington Section 2012/13 contacts list

We are always thankful for volunteers and members stepping forward to help the section run smoothly. If you'd like to learn more about how you could get involved, please email us at wellington@alpineclub.org.nz

Position	Name	Email alias*	Contact
Chairperson	Dan Pringle	chairperson	027 768-2185
Vice Chair	Vincent Zintzen	vicechair	
Secretary	Julian Davidson	secretary or CM2	
Treasurer	Adam Newberry	treasurer	
National Rep	Dan Pringle		
Patron	John Nankervis		
Trips	Vacant	Trips	
Other Committee Members	Simon Williamson		
	John Yu		
	Sharran Came		
Other Roles:			
Gear	vacant	gear	
Personal Locator Beacons	vacant	PLB	
Instruction Coordinator	vacant		
Instruction - AIC	vacant		
Instruction - Rock	vacant		
Library	Joke Meerkens	library	
Newsletter Editor	Carolyn Ellis		Kaz1963@gmail.com
Rock Drill Overseer	Kristen Foley	drill or KF	
Website	John Yu	webmaster	
* Email address is: alias@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz eg. secretary@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz			
Any membership, Distaghil Sar Fund, or general queries should be directed to the secretary			
Any media queries should be directed to:			
03 3777 595	National Executive Officer	Sam Newton	sam@alpineclub.org.nz



Shed 6 Queens Wharf
Wellingtons Waterfront
Ph 04 4998898 Fax 04 4998896
wn@fergskayaks.co.nz
www.fergskayaks.co.nz

Open 7 Days

Largest Real Rock Indoor Rock Wall – Kayaking – Inline Skates - Retail - Rental

Alpine Club members can climb any time for \$10
Monday nights show your Alpine Club card and climb for \$8

New routes every week*

\$1000 worth of new holds in Jan/Feb 2012

New pad in "Da Cave" allowing safe aggressive bouldering

Creating happiness through
better climbing

* to be precise, this is just an average but we do aim for new routes every single week.



**HangDog Rock Climbing
Adventures**

453 Hutt Rd
Lower Hutt
(04) 589 9181
info@hangdog.co.nz

www.hangdog.co.nz

i climb
.co.nz

Simond alpine equipment direct from the importer



Ocelot
\$115



MXC 820
\$230



Makalu
\$255



Caiman
\$230

all crampons include anti-balling plates
and crampon bag



i climb
.co.nz

If undelivered please return to:

NZAC Wellington Section

PO Box 1628

Wellington

